NORTHSTAR
DIGITAL SERVICES

Manager Leave Approval Guidelines

MANAGER • HR

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Prepared as synthetic content for a role-based retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) demonstration. This document is not an actual company policy.

Access classification: MANAGER • HR

1. Manager role and decision framework

Policy owner: HR Operations

Purpose

These guidelines help managers assess leave requests consistently while protecting employee wellbeing and operational coverage. They are internal management guidance for the fictional Northstar Digital Services demo.

Scope

Applies to managers who approve or coordinate employee leave. HR retains responsibility for interpreting policy, handling sensitive exceptions and advising on legal obligations.

Core standard

Apply published eligibility and notice rules consistently. Do not discourage lawful leave, retaliate against employees for using entitlements or make decisions based on protected characteristics or personal relationships.

Review sequence

Confirm the requested dates and leave type; check the HR system balance and eligibility; review team coverage and critical deadlines; identify any applicable legal or accommodation consideration; record a clear decision.

Coverage planning

Consider minimum staffing, essential skills, customer commitments, release windows and backup availability. Plan ahead where multiple employees request the same period rather than automatically favouring the most senior or vocal employee.

Decision authority

Managers may approve ordinary requests within their delegated authority. Requests involving exceptions, disputed balances, extended absences, protected leave or potential legal risk should be referred to HR.

2. Approvals, declines and escalation

Policy owner: HR Operations

Approval communication

Record approval in the official system and ensure the employee can see the dates and leave type. Do not rely solely on a verbal agreement or chat message when formal recording is required.

Declining a request

A decline should identify the relevant operational reason and, where feasible, propose alternative dates or a way to meet the employee's need. Avoid vague statements such as 'not a good time' without explaining the coverage issue.

Urgent absence

For illness or emergency, prioritize timely communication and follow the policy's reporting requirements. Do not require an employee to disclose unnecessary medical details. Coordinate with HR if documentation or accommodation questions arise.

Competing requests

Use a documented and consistently applied method such as rotation, request timing, business-critical coverage and prior holiday allocation. Explain the method to the team before peak periods.

Extended leave

Discuss handover and continuity needs with the employee, then consult HR about eligibility, required forms, privacy and return-to-work planning. Do not make promises about legal entitlements without confirmation.

Escalation triggers

Contact HR when a request involves a legal or contractual entitlement, disability or accommodation, pregnancy or parental leave, a complaint of unfair treatment, a disputed balance, or a proposed exception.

Recordkeeping

Keep decisions and operational rationale in approved systems. Avoid personal notes containing diagnoses, speculation or unnecessary sensitive details.

3. Scenarios and quality checks

Policy owner: HR Operations

Scenario: two critical team members request the same week

Check coverage options, cross-training and deadlines; apply the team's published priority method; explore partial overlap or alternate dates; document the decision and offer a clear explanation.

Scenario: employee reports sudden illness

Acknowledge the notice, record the absence through the correct channel and ask only for information required by policy. Refer documentation questions to HR.

Scenario: repeated balance discrepancy

Pause any punitive assumption, compare the system with approvals and attendance records, and ask HR to correct the source record if needed.

Scenario: request appears related to a protected entitlement

Do not decline based on ordinary staffing rules alone. Refer the request to HR promptly for a legal and policy review.

Manager checklist

Have I checked eligibility and balance? Is coverage reasoning objective? Have I considered alternatives? Is sensitive information minimized? Is the decision recorded? Do I need HR review?

Quality monitoring

HR may review anonymized approval patterns for unexplained differences across teams, recurring bottlenecks or inconsistent use of discretion. Managers should cooperate with reasonable audits.

Ownership

HR owns these guidelines. They supplement, but do not override, the employee leave policy, employment agreements or applicable law.